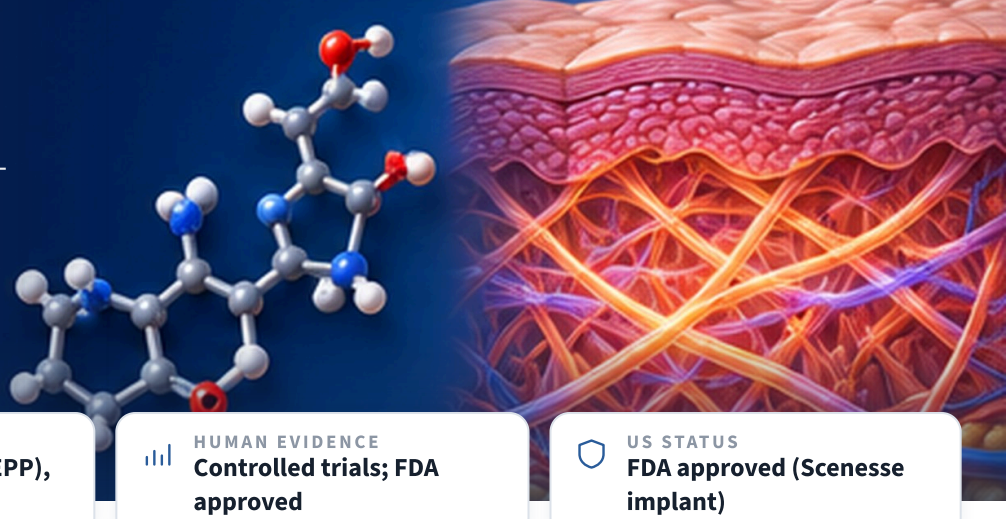
SKIN 10

Afamelanotide

Synthetic 13-amino-acid peptide built like alpha-MSH, the body's own skin-pigment signal



CLASS
Peptide (melanocortin agonist)

STUDIED FOR
Light-induced pain (EPP), vitiligo

HUMAN EVIDENCE
Controlled trials; FDA approved

US STATUS
FDA approved (Scenesse implant)

STUDIED FOR

EPP light pain
HUMAN

Vitiligo
HUMAN

Melanotan is a different product. Scenesse is the only afamelanotide product found with FDA approval. Melanotan peptides sold for tanning are not FDA approved.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Afamelanotide ▶ MC1 receptor ▶ More eumelanin ▶ Less light in skin

- **Binds mainly the MC1 receptor,** per the label
- **Raises eumelanin,** the brown-black pigment, without sun or UV light
- **In EPP,** more pigment cuts light reaching protoporphyrin IX (EMA)
- **Darkens** skin, moles and freckles

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- 2 Phase 3 EPP trials, 167 people
- US trial: 64.1 vs 40.5 pain-free sun hours
- EMA: added time in sunlight was small

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Cancer studies (not done)
- Full metabolic profile
- Drug interactions
- PK in liver or kidney disease

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE
About 15 hours (implant)

ROUTES STUDIED
Implant under the skin above the hip bone

PHARMACOKINETICS
Median peak at 36 hours; may undergo hydrolysis

SOLD AS
Prescription implant (Scenesse), placed by a professional

MONITORED IN TRIALS
Full body skin exam twice a year

SPORT (WADA)
Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved for EPP in adults (2019)
FDA	Melanotan peptides: no FDA approval
EMA	Authorised for EPP (2014), exceptional circumstances
WADA	Not on the 2026 list

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Scenesse prescribing information (DailyMed), May 2026
2. Langendonk et al., N Engl J Med, afamelanotide in EPP, Jul 2015
3. EMA, Scenesse EPAR, accessed Nov 2026

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